

FOUNDER NETWORK · ECOSYSTEM INTELLIGENCE

Funding, capital moves & founder news

Sourced and verified for the Brand Blueprint ecosystem — consumer / CPG, retail & DTC, pre-seed–Series A, US. Aug 4–13, 2026.



THE MARKET SIGNAL · FROM DANA

Your barcode is becoming a data system

GS1's **Sunrise 2027** push means retail point-of-sale systems will be able to read data-rich 2D barcodes — not just the old UPC — by the end of 2027. This isn't a QR-code trend; it's a packaging, product-data, and retail-readiness decision. The richer code can carry lot, batch, expiration, recall, and authenticity data.

The move: Pull your SKU and GTIN list, find your next packaging refresh, and pick *one* use case to pilot. Upgrade on your schedule, not under a buyer's deadline — the expensive path is redesigning packaging twice.

— Dana Ammons · Founder & Principal Strategist, The Brand Blueprint | Value Growth Partners

79%

more likely to buy a product with a useful scannable code

77%

say product information matters when they buy

62%

would spend more for detailed product information

1

Pull SKU + GTIN list

→

2

Pick one use case

→

3

Dual-mark: UPC + 2D

→

4

Test both paths

The founder's four-step path to a Sunrise-2027-ready package (source: GS1 US · FDA traceability guidance).

This issue's sweep: 9 verified opportunities & moves — web-sourced and cross-checked against your Gmail funding alerts (heavily filtered for relevance).

 Funding Radar 5

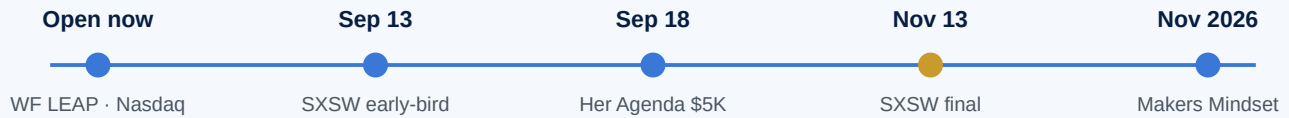
 Capital Moves 2

 Founder News 2

Filtered out 2 expired opportunities (CalNutri, Made for Retail Chicago) and ~90 days of off-target Gmail alerts (overseas fellowships, food-assistance and retail-staffing notices) that don't fit the founder audience.

 FUNDING RADAR

FUNDING DEADLINE RADAR



Whole Foods Market — 2026 Local & Emerging Accelerator (LEAP) [OPEN NOW](#)

Applications opened June 2026. Mentorship, expert coaching, programming, and potential direct financial support for emerging brands not yet on Whole Foods shelves.

Why it matters: A direct on-ramp to the leading natural-channel retailer for early CPG brands.

Deadline: Applications open **Fit:** US · CPG food & beverage · early-stage

Source: Whole Foods Market Newsroom — wholefoodsmarket.com/company-info/newsroom

Her Agenda — Breakthrough Grant (\$5,000 cash) [FROM YOUR ALERTS](#)

\$5,000 cash award for a woman entrepreneur with an operating business and a specific growth milestone. Requires an active Her Agenda newsletter subscription; \$25 application fee.

Why it matters: Direct, milestone-focused cash for revenue-stage women founders.

Deadline: Sept 18, 2026 **Fit:** US · women-led · operating business

Source: Her Agenda — grant.heragenda.com

SXSW Pitch 2026 — CPG & food-supply categories [EARLY-BIRD OPEN](#)

Early-bird entry June 23–Sept 13, 2026; final deadline Nov 13, 2026. Categories include CPG innovation and food supply systems.

Why it matters: National stage and investor audience; the early-bird window is open now.

Deadline: Early-bird Sept 13; final Nov 13, 2026 **Fit:** US · CPG/food innovation

Source: SXSW — sxsw.com/pitch

The Makers Mindset Grant — women-led CPG (equity-free)

Equity-free grant for women-led CPG brands (beauty, food, beverage, pet, home). US-based, 1+ year, \$50K–\$1M revenue. Three founders receive \$10,000 each, plus mentorship.

Why it matters: True non-dilutive capital and mentorship for revenue-stage women founders.

Deadline: Award notifications Nov 2026 **Fit:** US · women-led CPG · \$50K–\$1M

Source: Inc. Magazine — inc.com

Nasdaq Milestone Circles — Northwest Arkansas [FROM YOUR ALERTS](#)

Free 12-week milestone coaching, a peer cohort, and a paid student-internship pipeline for founders based in or operating in Northwest Arkansas (past idea stage, generally first 5 years).

Why it matters: Non-cash but high-value — execution capacity and a paid intern that reduce real operating costs.

Deadline: Rolling **Fit:** NW Arkansas · early revenue

Source: Nasdaq Entrepreneurial Center — nasdaqcenter.org/milestone-circles-ar

CAPITAL MOVES

Great Circle Ventures launches first growth-stage CPG fund [REVIEW: \\$ FIGURE](#)

Founder Jacob Afriat (formerly Danone Manifesto Ventures) is closing a ~\$20M follow-on fund for food & beverage brands impacting human and planetary health; early deployments include MOSH bars and Croots.

Why it matters: New growth-stage follow-on capital for better-for-you F&B — a fit for ecosystem brands raising after early traction.

Fit: US · food & beverage · growth-stage

Source: Forbes (Feb 23, 2026) — forbes.com/sites/andrewwatman

Paperboy Ventures launches CPG VC fund (media + funding)

Paperboy Ventures launched its first fund as a follow-on investor in early-stage consumer, expanding into a joint media-funding enterprise.

Why it matters: A media-plus-capital model relevant to founders building brand and distribution together.

Fit: US · consumer · early-stage

Source: Forbes (Nov 10, 2025) — forbes.com/sites/andrewwatman

FOUNDER NEWS

The Lucky Ox scales from Whole Foods Northeast to ~1,300 doors

The emerging beverage brand launched in Whole Foods' Northeast region and is now in roughly 1,300 doors nationwide.

Why it matters: A concrete example of the regional-to-national Whole Foods path early brands can model.

Fit: US · beverage · emerging

Source: Startup CPG Newswire — startupcpg.com/newswire

Ripi (frozen pasta) raises \$2.4M, rolls out at Target REVIEW: \$ FIGURE

Frozen pasta brand Ripi closed a \$2.4M round and is rolling out at Target — after landing both Whole Foods and Target within its first 15 months.

Why it matters: A fresh proof point on speed-to-retail and raising alongside distribution wins.

Fit: US · frozen food · early-stage

Source: Taste Radio (Ep. 829) — tasteradio.com

Flagged for your sign-off before send

Every capital figure needs your OK before it appears in a sent issue:

- Great Circle Ventures ~\$20M fund size · Ripi \$2.4M raise

Members: browse the full opportunity database →

Every item logged here lives in the Founder Network intelligence database, updated weekly, so members who miss an issue can still catch every open opportunity.



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